

# CHANGES IN SETTING

Moving the story to a new time or place



## 1 What is it?

### Changes In Setting

A change in setting moves the story to a **new time or place** — a shift that can signal a change in mood, mark the passage of time, or contrast two different worlds.

setting A → setting B

## 2 See it in action

Contrasting worlds

The story moves from a cramped, grey city to an open, sunlit countryside.

Marking time passing

A jump from a snowy winter scene to a description of spring blossom.

Signalling danger

Moving from a safe, familiar home into an unfamiliar, threatening forest.

Symbolic setting

A character moves from a locked room to an open field, mirroring new freedom.



**Mfalme says...**

When the setting changes, always ask: **what has changed about the mood, and why did the writer choose THIS new place** at exactly this point in the story?

### FUN FACT

In many classic stories, a journey from an enclosed setting (a house, a village) to an open one (a forest, the sea) structurally mirrors a character growing in freedom or self-understanding.

### 3 Why writers use it

**Changes In Setting helps writers:** signal an emotional or thematic shift without stating it directly, mark the passage of time, and use contrasting settings to highlight a character's change or a story's central conflict.

Setting isn't just background — a change in setting is often used to physically represent an internal, emotional change happening inside a character.

### 4 Where you'll spot it

#### Travel and journey narratives

Each new setting often marks a new stage in the character's development.

#### Fantasy & adventure fiction

A shift from the ordinary world to a magical one is often the story's major structural turning point.



#### Watch out!

A change in setting is more than just "the location changed" — always link it to WHY: what mood, theme or character change does the new setting reflect?



#### Look here!

Look for **contrast** between settings — a peaceful place followed by a dangerous one (or vice versa) is a deliberate structural technique worth naming.

### 5 Quick recap

Story moves to a new  
time or place

Can signal mood or time  
passing

Often mirrors an internal  
change



#### You got this!

Try describing the same character's feelings in two totally different settings — a busy street, then an empty beach — notice how the setting itself changes the tone.